



1545–1790

The age of discovery

In the 16th century, new scientific knowledge replaced old ways of thinking. The invention of the microscope and the telescope stimulated the study of anatomy and astronomy. Long-distance travel at sea led to more accurate ways of measuring distance and time. These advances created a need for complex calculations, which brought about advances in mathematics. Instead of relying on traditional teaching, scientists (then known as natural philosophers) began to test ideas and theories through observation, investigation, and experimentation. Their discoveries laid the foundations of modern science.